MSU-General Santos City

Mindanao State University – General Santos (MSU-GenSan or MSU Gensan) is a public state higher education institution and a constituent university of the Mindanao State University System. Located primarily in Barangay Fatima, General Santos City, Philippines, it serves as a key provider of accessible tertiary education in the SOCCSKSARGEN region and neighboring areas of Southern Mindanao.

It operates under the broader MSU mandate, established by Republic Act 1387 (as amended), to educate the youth of Mindanao, Sulu, and Palawan (MINSUPALA), support regional economic development through trained manpower, and promote the integration of Muslims, Indigenous Peoples, and other cultural communities into national life. As part of the only state university system with this explicit integration and peace-oriented charter, MSU-GenSan emphasizes inclusive education, research, extension, and community engagement.

The university reports more than 9,500 students (over 8,600 undergraduates in recent figures), with colors of maroon and gold, the motto "Learn, Achieve, Excel," and the alma mater song Himno ng Pamantasang Mindanao (music by Lucio San Pedro, lyrics by Prof. Angelito G. Flores). Its official website is msugensan.edu.ph.

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History and Founding

MSU-GenSan began in September 1967 as a community high school, six years after the founding of the MSU main campus in Marawi in 1961. It was initially hosted inside Dadiangas West Elementary School in central General Santos City. Local support, including involvement from figures such as Jacobino Java Sr. (principal of Dadiangas West), helped establish it.

To address growing enrollment, the city government donated a 3.3-hectare lot in the city center for the high school. It expanded into a junior college around 1971, limited at first to two-year general education programs. On October 10, 1973, by Board of Regents (BOR) Resolution No. 822, it became a full-fledged collegiate campus of the MSU System, initially offering two-year degree courses and focusing on areas such as agribusiness.

Engr. Abedin Limpao Osop served as the first director of the then MSU Community College and later as the first chancellor. The campus underwent physical transfers as it grew. In 1980 (or 1983 according to some university summaries), Presidential Proclamation No. 2029 reserved land in what is now Barangay Fatima (formerly part of Tambler) as a civil reservation for the MSU General Santos unit (and human settlements). Official university pages

and Wikipedia commonly cite 1983 and a 156-hectare main campus; the proclamation text itself is dated November 11, 1980, and describes a larger aggregate area of which the university portion became the core campus. This acquisition enabled significant expansion of degree programs and facilities.

The university gained greater autonomy around 1981. It has continued to expand academic offerings, infrastructure, and roles in research and community service. In June 2026, a major Mindanao earthquake caused substantial damage estimated near ₱870 million to buildings and facilities; recovery and rehabilitation efforts followed, with some activities shifting online temporarily.

Vision, Mission, and Core Values

According to the official university site (updated via BOR Resolution No. 386, Series of 2025):

- **Vision**: A leading transformative University driving excellence, research, innovation, and sustainable peace and development.
- **Mission**: To produce competent human resources committed to the development of the Philippines and to help uplift the living conditions of Muslims, Indigenous Peoples, and other underserved communities.
- **Core Values (I-RISE)**: Integrity, Respect, Inclusivity, Service, Excellence. Earlier statements described a vision of becoming a globally competitive university in Southern Philippines and a mission focused on competent human resources for Southern Mindanao while improving conditions for Muslims and Indigenous Peoples. The 2025 revision aligns more explicitly with system-wide goals of transformation, peace, and inclusive development.

Campus and Location

The main campus covers approximately 156 hectares in Barangay Fatima, General Santos City (coordinates roughly 6°03′59″N 125°07′34″E). It houses most academic colleges, administrative offices, and facilities, and includes a Philippine Institute of Volcanology and Seismology (PHIVOLCS) seismic station. Additional sites include:

- A 3.3-hectare campus in the city center (Dadiangas/CETD area) used for the College of Medicine, School of Graduate Studies, College of Law (extension), laboratory high school, and related programs, often with evening or weekend classes.
- A field laboratory/research station of about 3.1 hectares in Barangay Siguel (or Bawing in some references) for the College of Fisheries and Aquatic Sciences. The university also operates a laboratory junior high school (MSU-CETD) and Senior High School Department under the College of Education.

Academic Structure and Programs

MSU-GenSan comprises multiple colleges and institutes, including Agriculture; Business Administration and Accountancy; Education; Engineering; Fisheries and Aquatic Sciences; Health Sciences (Nursing); Natural Sciences and Mathematics; Social Sciences and Humanities; the Institute of Islamic, Arabic, and International Studies; College of Medicine (established 2021, first graduates in 2025); and a College of Law extension of the main campus.

Undergraduate offerings span BS programs in Agricultural Business Management, Agricultural & Biosystems Engineering, Agriculture, Accountancy, Economics, Business Administration, Elementary and Secondary Education, Physical Education, Civil/Electrical/Electronics/Mechanical Engineering, Engineering Technology, Fisheries, Marine Biology, Nursing, Biology, Information Technology, Mathematics, Chemistry, Physics, various

BA degrees (English Language Studies, Literary and Cultural Studies, Filipino, History, Political Science, Sociology, Psychology), Islamic Studies (including Shariah major), and International Relations, among others. Diploma and certificate programs exist in technical fields.

Graduate programs include master's degrees in Agribusiness Management, Business Management (various majors), Education, Teaching, Public Administration, Sustainable Development (multiple majors), Biology, Mathematics, Information Technology, Philippine Studies, Filipino, and a PhD in Educational Management, plus a Doctor in Sustainable Development Studies. The Doctor of Medicine is a post-baccalaureate program. Admission is primarily through the MSU System Admission and Scholarship Examination (MSU-SASE). Tuition is generally free under RA 10931 for eligible students.

Research, Extension, and Community Engagement

The university maintains research and extension functions aligned with regional needs in agriculture, fisheries, education, sustainable development, peace, and health. Units include research and extension divisions, a Halal Research and Training Center, and the Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao. It engages communities through outreach, supports peacebuilding consistent with the MSU charter, and has produced publications in indexed journals. CHED has recognized it in areas such as Center of Excellence in Fisheries, Provincial Institute for Agriculture, and Center of Training in Education.

Administration and Governance

As a constituent university, MSU-GenSan is headed by a chancellor (elected for a five-year term) who sits on the MSU Board of Regents. The current chancellor is **Atty. Shidik T. Abantas, MDM, LLM** (seventh regular chancellor, inaugurated around April 2025). The MSU System president is **Atty. Paisalin P. Tago**. Vice chancellors oversee Academic Affairs, Administration and Finance, Research/Extension/Innovation, Planning and Development, and Student Affairs and Services.

Early leadership included **Engr. Abedin Limpao Osop** (*first director/chancellor*), followed by figures such as **Dr. Datumanong A. Sarangani** (*second chancellor*), and later leaders including **Dr. Anshari P. Ali** (who advanced the College of Medicine). Full historical lists of all chancellors are not comprehensively detailed in publicly accessible official summaries.

Accreditation, Recognition, and Milestones

MSU-GenSan joined the Accrediting Agency of Chartered Colleges and Universities in the Philippines (AACCUP) on December 31, 2014, and has pursued program accreditations (including Level III for some programs such as BA Islamic Studies). It has received CHED's Excellence in Quality Assurance in Teacher Education (EQUATE) Award, performed strongly in licensure examinations (including multiple topnotchers in the LET), and earned placements in rankings such as Webometrics (around 63rd in the Philippines in one recent edition) and Times Higher Education Sustainability Impact Ratings. The College of Medicine marked a regional milestone as the first of its kind in Region XII, with its inaugural graduates in 2025. ISO 21001:2018 processes have also been pursued.

Significant milestones include the 1967 founding as a high school, 1973 elevation to collegiate status, land acquisition enabling campus growth, expansion of graduate and professional programs (including Medicine), and ongoing quality assurance efforts amid challenges such as the 2026 earthquake.

Student Life, Traditions, and Culture

Student life includes organizations, cultural activities, sports, and the laboratory schools. The university reflects Mindanao's diversity (Bangsamoro, Lumad/Indigenous, Christian, and other communities) and emphasizes peace, inclusivity, and service. Specific longstanding traditions beyond the system alma mater song and commencement exercises (recent batches named such as Maragsâ and Magdarani) are not extensively detailed in official public materials reviewed. The official seal features a lamp of knowledge, Okir (Maranao) motifs, three rays representing MINSUPALA, and a SOCCSKSARGEN map reference.

Notable Alumni and Faculty

Publicly highlighted alumni include actress and comedian Melisa Cantiveros (noted on Wikipedia, though primary verification is limited). Faculty and leadership include deans and researchers contributing to regional scholarship in education, engineering, fisheries, social sciences, Islamic studies, and medicine (e.g., College of Medicine Dean Dr. Edwin C. Alconcel). Comprehensive lists of notable alumni or faculty are not centrally published in the sources consulted; many graduates serve in education, government, agriculture, health, engineering, and community leadership roles across Southern Mindanao and beyond.

Contributions and Legacy

MSU-GenSan contributes to regional human capital development, particularly in agriculture, fisheries, teacher education, engineering, health, and Islamic/Arabic studies relevant to Bangsamoro and broader Mindanao communities. It supports peace education, cultural integration, and economic needs in SOCCSKSARGEN while advancing the MSU System's national integration mandate. Its growth from a community high school to a multi-campus institution with professional programs (including the region's first College of Medicine) illustrates sustained local and system support. The 2026 earthquake underscored both vulnerability and resilience as rehabilitation continues.

Research Assessment

This article draws primarily from the official MSU-GenSan website (msugensan.edu.ph), the MSU Main Campus site (msumain.edu.ph), Wikipedia entries cross-checked against official pages, government proclamations (e.g., Proclamation No. 2029 via Lawphil), CHED-related announcements, news reports on recent events (e.g., Rappler on earthquake damage), and secondary academic or public references. Priority was given to institutional and government sources.

Verified Facts: Founding as community high school in 1967; elevation via BOR Resolution 822 on October 10, 1973; main campus land via Presidential Proclamation 2029 (1980 text, commonly referenced as 1983 acquisition); current chancellor Atty. Shidik T. Abantas; vision/mission/core values per 2025 BOR resolution; approximate campus sizes and locations; major colleges and sample programs; AACCUP membership from 2014; College of Medicine establishment and first graduates; student population figures around 9,500; earthquake damage in 2026.

Information Not Yet Verified or Incomplete: Exact complete chronological list of all chancellors/directors with precise terms; detailed founding individuals beyond Osop and early local supporters; comprehensive inventories of accredited programs with current levels; exhaustive lists of notable alumni/faculty; precise breakdown of research outputs or extension impact metrics; full historical enrollment trends; detailed traditions or student organization histories; exact current land area reconciliation (156 ha commonly stated vs. proclamation aggregate).

Research Gaps: Limited publicly digitized institutional archives or annual reports for early decades; sparse independent academic histories; incomplete cross-verification of some Wikipedia details against primary documents; evolving post-2026 recovery data; and the need for official confirmation of any program-specific CHED Centers of Excellence status beyond summarized claims. Future research would benefit from direct access to BOR minutes, university yearbooks, and local government records. The article maintains a neutral, factual tone based on available authoritative sources. Discrepancies (such as the 1980 vs. 1983 dating of the land proclamation or minor variations in campus size reports) are noted where they appear; the official university narrative and primary legal text are preferred where conflicts arise.

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